expert in kinetics, was uneasy with it from the start, and there would be bound to be someone on the committee who would see the error at a glance.

But if I abandoned the mechanism, I could not complete my dissertation, and I would not get my Ph.D. I would have to start all over again—perhaps even on another problem.

At 4:00 p.m. on March 1, 1948, then, I saw my Ph.D. go glimmering down the same path as "Grow Old with Me" had gone. Was this what it had all come to, all those years of child prodigiousness—just one coruscating, spectacular failure?

I had to do something. I couldn't see Dawson. He was in conference with another professor who had ripped up the dissertation of a fellow student. (That sort of thing did happen!)

So I went to the Henry Paper Box Company, where Gertrude was

engaged in her usual stint, and insisted on going to the movies. This was in accordance with a theory of mine in which, under the pressure of panic, the thinking process goes into a circular rut from which it cannot emerge. The thing to do, then, is to distract one's self just enough to free the thinking and yet not distract one's self so much that thinking ceases altogether. The best way (for me) is to see a superficial movie that amuses the skin of my brain but not the muscle underneath.

We went to see Bob Hope in Where There's Life, which was perfect for the purpose. I emerged with a couple of alternate mechanisms that avoided the fallacy and that might, however, explain the observations.

By March 5, I finally got to see Dawson, explained the fallacy shamefacedly, and suggested the alternate mechanism, which I had bounced off Tarpley successfully and which was so much simpler that no fallacy could hide in it.

Dawson was, as usual, not surprised either at my stupidity or at the way I owned up to it, and was his usual encouraging self. He had me see some faculty members who specialized in such matters and I received a quick education from them.

I went back to writing the dissertation on the new basis, and the sense of panic subsided. In March, I saw Dawson nearly every other day and spent hours, it seemed to me, on single paragraphs. The deadline for turning in the dissertation in completed form was April 15, and I have never approached an